

British liberalism



At the end of the 18th century, rapidly industrializing nations in Europe and America sought to establish democratic institutions. Following the revolutions in America and France, constitutions were drawn up to ensure social justice and individual freedoms. Britain's own revolution, a century before, had established a constitutional monarchy, and British political philosophers were arguably in a better position to theorize about the organization of democratic society and the balance between authority and liberty. While elsewhere in Europe the emphasis on metaphysics remained, British thinkers focused on moral and political philosophy, building on the

legacy of social contract theory and Hume's practical empiricism (see [The social contract](#) and [Hume and causality](#)). A tradition of liberalism (in the sense of *laissez-faire*, rather than left-wing) emerged in the conservative liberalism of Edmund Burke and economic liberalism of Adam Smith. Jeremy Bentham, meanwhile, proposed a more radical moral and political philosophy that was to influence the most prominent 19th-century British philosopher, John Stuart Mill.